in language and concepts. One such case is the designation of 'the reality of reality' as 'not thus, not thus' at *Brihadaranyaka Upanishad* 2.3.6. The *Advaita-Vedantin* thinker ***Shankara*** says that this helps us understand the nature of the ultimate reality by excluding from it every finite and variable factor. It expresses something that has no distinguishing features: neither name, form, action, difference, genus nor quality that are the grounds for the applications of words. Since the Absolute has no features, it cannot be described as 'this' or 'that'. The Absolute may be provisionally thought of in terms of name, form and action superimposed upon it. But we can only indicate what it is in itself by denying of it all descriptions that apply to aspects of the cosmos.

Brahman, the universal source beyond all oppositions, is not existent in the same way in which worldly objects are. We cannot say that ***Brahman*** and empirical objects exist in the same sense of 'exist'.

Shankara thinks that the descriptive *Upanishadic* statements do not convey saving knowledge directly but they help to turn the mind away from the world and towards what is divine. Even the most elevated thoughts do not express the ultimate truth since they belong to the sphere of ***avidya*** and presuppose the reality of differences.

Further reading: Bartley 2002

Nirakaravada (awareness is formless): the ***Vaibhashika*** Buddhists, ***Nyaya-Vaisheshikas***, ***Purva Mimamsakas*** and *Vedantins* agree that consciousness scans and illuminates external objects without undergoing any intrinsic change. To say that awareness lacks form means that cognitions are differentiated by the objects that cause them. It does not commit one to the view that there is any undifferentiated consciousness or blank cognitions waiting for objects. The ***Nyaya*** school holds that, in a true cognition, the mental image is a copy of the object.